

Detailed Tour Itinerary of Everest Base Camp Helicopter Tour

5:30 AM: Hotel Pickup in Kathmandu

Our Mountain Helicopter Nepal representatives will pick you up from your Kathmandu hotel in a private vehicle and confirm your pickup time and hotel address the evening before the flight. If your hotel is located in Thamel, Lazimpat or central Kathmandu then pickup takes 15-20 minutes to reach the Tribhuvan International Airport.

6:00 AM: Arrival at Tribhuvan International Airport (Domestic Terminal)

After the pickup you are directly taken to the domestic terminal helipad area of the airport. There at the airport our ground team will have already processed your permit documentation the previous day and at the helipad:

- You will receive your Sagarmatha National Park entry permit and your Khumbu Pasang Lhamu Rural Municipality permit
- You will be attending a mandatory preflight safety briefing that includes, oxygen use, emergency procedures, what to do at the altitude etc.
- You are introduced to our CAAN certified mountain pilots
- And you will undergo weight checking of luggage and passenger

NOTE FOR WEIGHT CHECKING: Our Airbus H125 operates under strict weight limits at high altitude due to reduced air density above 4,000m. In this stage all passengers are weighted individually. If your group exceeds 4-5 people then the group will be split into two shuttle rotations, one group will land at Kala Patthar and the helicopter returns for the remaining group. Thus, both groups will spend the same time at all landing points. This is a standard safe aviation procedure and not any indication of a problem.

6:30 AM: Departure from Kathmandu

The helicopter will lift from Kathmandu heading northeast and immediately you will be seeing the open view of Kathmandu valley, the city, temples etc. within 10 minutes there will be a view of Himalayan foothills and the first line of middle hills. Our pilot provides live commentary, identifying landmarks and peaks as they appear.

7:15 AM: Refueling Stop at Lukla, Tenzing-Hillary Airport (2,860m)

There will be a 15–20-minute technical stop for refueling at Lukla airport. Lukla is famous for its extremely short runway (527 meters). It is a one-end uphill design on a mountain cliff at the far end. While refueling you can step out shortly and observe the airport which serves as a trekking gateway for all Everest expeditions.

7:35 AM: Flyover at Namche Bazaar (3,440m)

Namche Bazaar is a cool place that is shaped like a horseshoe. It is the start of the Khumbu and also the way into the Khumbu. On Saturdays the market in Namche Bazaar is a lot of fun. You can see the market place. There are bakeries and teahouses everywhere. All the terraces in Namche Bazaar will be full of people on Saturdays. They will be having a great time on Saturday. The people of Namche Bazaar and the visitors to Namche Bazaar really enjoy Saturdays, in Namche Bazaar. This is where all trekkers spend their mandatory first rest day.

7:40 AM: Flyover at Tengboche Monastery (3,860m)

A most holy site for the Buddhists in the region, located on the edge of a steep cliff ridge in between Imja and Dudh Kosi valley. It is the most famous buddhist monastery in Khumbu region. This monastery was built in 1916 and was destroyed by the 1934 earthquake, it was rebuilt but again burned in a fire in 1989 and then restored again in 1993. On clear autumn days, the sound of monks praying echoes in the valley.

7:45 AM: Flyover at Periche (4,240m)

The helicopter ride continues to flyover at Periche which is a high-altitude village at 4,240m that serves as a rest point for trekkers. There is a medical clinic run by Himalayan Rescue Association specifically for altitude sickness. It is also used as the rotation point where partial groups land and wait.

7:52 AM: Flyover at Everest Base Camp (5,364m)

An iconic fly past the helicopter buzzes low above Everest Base Camp itself. From above the tent-filled Khumbu Glacier is visible, rows of brightly-colored domes of expedition tents, the temporary village populated by numerous dozens of international teams during the height of the climbing season (April – May). Just outside of the base camp. Khumbu Icefall is located, an ice chunk mountain known as seracs, full of deep crevasses.

Landings: Please note the current Civil Aviation Authority of Nepal (CAAN) operating procedures do not allow scheduled tourist helicopter landing at Everest Base Camp glacier as this damages the fragile surface and potentially disrupts expedition work there. Your actual landing is on Kala Patthar, which has better views and is the worldwide number one vantage point for the Everest summit face.

7:55 AM: Landing at Kala Patthar (5,545m / 18,192 ft)

You land on Kala Patthar, the highest point of the whole trip and truly one of the most breathtaking spots on the surface of this Earth you'll ever be standing in without using a climbing rack. Kala Patthar is the high, rocky apex on the south wall of Pumori in Nepal, at an altitude of 5545m; in English it is known as the black rock. From the helipad on Kala Patthar, you're at a truly amazing viewpoint, 360 degrees with unobstructed views.

What you can view from Kala Patthar:

- Mount Everest (8,848.86m) - The entire southwest face, summit pyramid and Hillary step are clearly visible.
- Lhotse (8,516m): linked to Everest by the South Col.
- Nuptse (7,861m): the immense western face that joins Everest.
- Pumori (7,161m): it's directly above you and behind.
- Khumbu Icefall: it's the terrifying section of fractured ice descending between you and Western Cwm.
- Khumbu Glacier: it lies down below you extending to the Base Camp.
- Everything at the Base Camp below which is sitting on the glacier moraine.

Ground time at Kala patthar is 10-15 minutes

As atmospheric pressure at 5,545m is roughly 53% of that at sea level, the oxygen level in the air that you are breathing will also be approximately halved. For this reason, you may feel:

- Feeling out of breath, even for short distances such as the stairs or going for a walk.
- Feeling lightheaded when you stand up suddenly.
- Your resting pulse rate increases a little higher than usual.
- You may be more sensitive to the cold than usual.

That's a completely normal bodily reaction to gaining altitude this quickly. For a fit and healthy individual only there for 10-15 min there is no risk. The helicopter pilot will not leave the vehicle and will be watching you all, we can drop straight down at any sign of significant acute distress, you get chest pain, or unable to stand. There is an emergency supply of oxygen too.

A photography note: set up on the south side for the optimum view of Everest's face. The light is best in the morning usually. It's for exactly that reason why we leave here at 6.30. Be sure to have your camera fully charged and have it in an inside jacket pocket, it doesn't take long for the cold to drain the battery.

8:15 AM: Breakfast at Hotel Everest View, Syangboche (3880m)

After the Kalapathar landing, the helicopter lands at Syangboche where the Hotel Everest View sits on an unobstructed frontal view of Mount Everest, Lhotse, Ama Dablam and Thamserku. The Hotel Everest View is recognized as the world's highest permanent hotel, holding a Guinness World Record.

Your hot traditional Nepali Breakfast:

- Dal bhat (Lentil soup with rice) OR Western Breakfast Choices
- Fresh eggs, toast, or pancakes
- Hot tea, coffee or local butter tea

The mountain scenery in the dining room contains the familiar figure of Ama Dablam (6,812m) at the front of Thamserku (6,608m), Kantega (6,685m) and the vast white expanse of the Khumbu region.

Breakfast takes 45 – 60 minutes to digest. Your body needs time to readjust to lower altitude as you prepare for the return flight to Kathmandu. This is not just time for the physical, it is vital to your body to readjust from altitude.

9:30 AM: Return Flight to Kathmandu

We follow our route back down through the Khumbu Valley – past Tengboche, across Namche, over the Dudh Koshi gorge, perhaps stop for fuel in Lukla and then south over the foothills back to Kathmandu.

This is a short 45–55-minute flight.

10:15-10:30 AM: Drop-Off at Kathmandu Hotel

We pick you up from the airport and drop you off right at your hotel in Kathmandu. By before mid-morning you are back, and all afternoon is yours.